PRIVACY

LIFE ONLINE

UNIT 3

WARM-UP SPEAKING

Discuss the questions below with a partner, or answer each one in about 30 seconds.

1. How often do you use the internet?

2. Do you check your privacy settings online? Why?

3. Do you share personal information online? Why or why not?

4. Do you feel safe talking to strangers online? Why or why not?

Article & Vocabulary

UNDERSTANDING KEY VOCABULARY

Article 1

Read the sentences. Match each word in bold to its definition (a–f).

1 His **hostile** response to the interviewer's questions made viewers feel genuinely uncomfortable.
2 She felt overwhelming **humiliation** when screenshots of her private messages began circulating without her permission.
3 No one should have to tolerate **abusive** comments simply for sharing an honest opinion online.
4 After weeks of unwanted messages, he decided to **withdraw** from the app completely.
5 The court's ruling set an important **precedent** that several other judges have since followed.
6 The app allows users to post under complete **anonymity**, without ever revealing their real names.

a (adj) unfriendly; showing strong dislike
b (n) shame and loss of self-respect
c (adj) rude and offensive; causing another person mental or physical harm
d (v) to stop taking part in something
e (n) an earlier action or decision that becomes an example for future decisions
f (n) the situation in which somebody's name or identity is not known

Complete the sentences with the correct form of a word from either article.

1 She described the whole experience as deeply _____. (humiliate)
2 Some comment sections online are filled with open _____ towards anyone who disagrees. (hostile)
3 Companies now face growing pressure to accept more _____ for how they handle user data. (accountable)
4 There was no _____ behind the mistake — it was simply a careless error. (malicious)
5 Local officials have promised stronger _____ of online platforms operating in the region. (regulate)

LIFE BEHIND THE SCREEN

1 Almost everyone who spends real time online eventually runs into behaviour that feels openly **hostile** — a stranger mocking a photo, a pile of insulting replies under an honest opinion, or worse. For a graphic designer we'll call Elena, it started with a single unkind comment about her portfolio and slowly grew into a stream of **abusive** messages that arrived every time she posted new work. She is far from alone. Cyber harassment, unwanted and repeated hostile behaviour carried out online, has become one of the more troubling costs of living a large part of our lives on the internet.

2 A recent survey of internet users found that well over half had witnessed this kind of behaviour directed at someone else, and roughly a third said they had experienced it personally. Even these figures likely understate the real scale of the problem, since many people never report what happens to them, either because they doubt anything will change or because they feel a private sense of **humiliation** about the whole situation.

3 Why does this behaviour happen at all? The **anonymity** the internet offers is often blamed first. When a username replaces a real face, some people say and do things they would never consider face-to-face. Anonymity also makes harassment easier to get away with, since a harasser can simply create a new account after being blocked or reported, appearing again under a different name with no history attached.

4 Researchers who have studied this behaviour, however, caution against assuming every troll fits a single profile. Some data **assembled** from harassment reports does show a small number of unusually active, deliberately **malicious** users responsible for a disproportionate share of the abuse. But a surprisingly large share of hostile comments come from ordinary users who behave badly only occasionally, often anonymously, and often without much thought about the person on the receiving end.

5 Legal responses vary enormously from one country to another. Some countries have updated older laws to specifically cover online threats and stalking; others still rely on rules written long before social media existed, leaving significant gaps. Even where laws exist on paper, relatively few offenders are ever formally **prosecuted**, since gathering evidence and identifying an anonymous account can be slow and difficult, and cases frequently cross national borders.

6 Some legal experts argue that limiting anonymity altogether would help hold people **accountable**, since it is harder to behave abusively under your own name. Others push back, pointing out that anonymity also protects people who genuinely need it — whistle-blowers, activists in hostile political environments, or simply someone quietly researching a sensitive personal question they would rather keep private. Removing anonymity for everyone, they argue, would punish the many to catch a much smaller number of bad actors, without necessarily changing their behaviour much at all.

7 For victims, in the meantime, the impact rarely feels abstract. Many describe genuine humiliation, lasting anxiety, and a reluctance to post anything at all, even long after the original comments have disappeared. Some, like Elena, eventually **withdraw** from a platform entirely rather than continue putting new work in front of an audience that might turn hostile again — a quiet, largely invisible cost that rarely appears in any survey.

Match headings A–H to paragraphs 1–7 of Article 1. There is one extra heading you do not need.

A A single comment among many

B When the numbers still fall short of the full picture

C Hiding behind a different name each time

D Not every troll fits the same profile

E Laws that struggle to keep pace

F The debate over ending anonymity

G A quiet, largely invisible ending

H Legal action available to every victim

MATCH THE HEADING

LANGUAGE DEVELOPMENT - Collocations for behaviour

VOCABULARY SKILL

Verb + noun collocations

Certain verbs regularly combine with the same small set of nouns to describe behaviour and its effects — for example **exhibit hostile behaviour**, or **lose confidence**. Learning these as whole chunks, rather than word by word, makes your language sound far more

build	*a reputation, confidence*
exhibit	*behaviour (hostile/abusive)*
exprience	*abuse, pain, behaviour*
lose	*confidence, a reputation*
suffer	*abuse, pain*
take	*responsibility*

Complete each sentence with one verb (in the correct form) and one noun from the table above. In some items, more than one answer is possible.

1 When something goes wrong with an account, it helps to _____ _____ promptly and explain what happened.

2 Our platform has _____ _____ for responding quickly to reports of abuse.

3 People who _____ _____ online often decide to leave a platform altogether.

4 It isn't only strangers who _____ hostile _____ — some abuse comes from people users actually know.

5 Long-term harassment can cause people to _____ _____ that is both emotional and physical.

6 Even a single hostile comment can cause a person to _____ _____ and stop posting altogether.

UNDERSTANDING KEY VOCABULARY

Article 2

2 The sentences below are about online behaviour and its consequences. Choose the correct meaning (a, b or c) for the word in bold.

1 Company leaders should be held **accountable for** decisions that put users' personal data at risk.

a punished

b aware

c responsible

2 Authorities have promised to **prosecute** anyone who deliberately spreads someone's private photos without consent.

a search for in order to arrest

b take to court to argue the guilt of

c commit a crime against

3 The message contained **malicious** software specifically designed to steal people's banking details.

a legal but inappropriate

b untruthful

c intended to cause harm

4 No platform can completely **eliminate** the risk of personal data being leaked somewhere.

a remove entirely

b find a punishment for

c reduce slightly

5 Researchers **assembled** a database of thousands of harassment reports in order to study the problem.

a gathered

b interviewed

c attracted

6 New automated tools have been developed to **combat** the spread of fake profiles on social media.

a evaluate

b try to stop

c destroy

7 Several governments are now working to **regulate** how companies collect and store personal information.

a control

b encourage

c tax

8 Accounts that **exhibit** unusual posting patterns are often flagged automatically by the platform's systems.

a create

b accept

c show

CAN ONLINE COMMUNITIES POLICE THEMSELVES?

1 Tackling cyber harassment usually requires a two-pronged effort: preventing bad behaviour in the first place, and penalising it after the fact. So far, most attention has gone into prevention, partly because it is so difficult to **eliminate** harmful behaviour once it has already reached a victim. Anonymity again complicates things here — placing new limits on how people interact online could genuinely reduce harassment, but it risks damaging the openness that makes online communities valuable in the first place.

2 Online gaming has often been treated as an unusually difficult case, given how much casual interaction happens there and how much abuse female players in particular report. One large multiplayer game, after studying its own community, **assembled** a research team to examine chat logs from a huge sample of its regular players. The team's early expectation was that a small number of consistently badly behaved players would be responsible for most of the abuse — and while it did find a handful of genuinely malicious repeat offenders, most of the offensive messages actually came from otherwise ordinary players who simply behaved badly occasionally. Notably, disabling public chat by default cut abusive messages by close to a third, suggesting that a small structural change can meaningfully **combat** bad behaviour before it even starts.

3 Other communities have taken a different route: letting users **regulate** each other. Several platforms now allow members to rate or report one another, similar to how buyers and sellers on some online marketplaces already rate each other after a transaction. Reputation systems like this give ordinary users a visible incentive to avoid behaving in ways that would get them flagged, without requiring a company to review every single message by hand. Some services also use automated systems trained to flag accounts that **exhibit** repeated aggressive language or unusually poor spelling — patterns that, on their own, weakly predict harassing behaviour but become useful signals in combination.

4 Government regulation has been slower to catch up. Several countries have extended older laws to cover online threats and stalking more clearly, yet very few offenders are ever formally prosecuted under them, since gathering usable evidence against an anonymous account is genuinely difficult and often expensive. One notable court decision, allowing a harassment victim to identify an anonymous account holder through legal channels, set a **precedent** that several other courts have since followed. Experts frequently offer victims the same advice — simply ignore the harassment and avoid responding to it — but many victims say that, while well-meant, this advice does little to make ongoing abuse actually stop.

5 As more of everyday life moves online, addressing this behaviour matters more each year, not less. The internet is no longer a separate space we can easily walk away from; increasingly, it's where people socialise, work, and build a reputation that follows them elsewhere. Treating online harassment as a minor inconvenience, rather than behaviour with real social, professional, and even economic costs, is an attitude that is slowly, if unevenly, starting to change.

GRAMMAR FOR WRITING

GRAMMAR

Impersonal passive constructions & the passive for continuity

Writers often choose the passive voice when the agent is 'people'. As a subject, 'people' may be too general or repetitive. When reporting what people think or say, writers create a passive with no apparent agent, using two common constructions.

These constructions often appear with the verbs agree, argue, believe, claim, consider, decide, expect, say, think and understand. Note that not all of these verbs allow both patterns equally naturally.

1. **It is + said/believed/argued/thought + that + clause** — used when reporting a general opinion with no named source.

It is said that cyber harassment is most common in online spaces where anonymity is easiest to maintain.

2. **Subject + is/are + said/believed/thought/considered + to + infinitive** — the same idea, with the topic as the subject.

Stricter regulation is believed to be one of the most effective ways to reduce online abuse.

3. The passive is also useful for keeping the same subject across two clauses, making a sentence easier to follow.

Because the harassment takes place online, it is not always taken seriously.

4. When using the passive for continuity, the by-phrase is usually omitted if the agent is unclear or unimportant.

The account had been reported many times before it was finally suspended.

Exercise A — Rewrite sentences 1–4 in the impersonal passive in two ways. For sentences 5 and 6, only one construction is natural.

1 People believe that these figures underestimate the true scale of the problem.

2 People claim that anonymous accounts are responsible for most abusive comments.

3 People expect that victims of harassment will eventually stop using the platform.

4 People understand that self-regulation is the most realistic short-term solution.

5 People consider ignoring the harassment to be sensible advice for victims.

6 People have argued that these problems will require a stronger legal response.

Exercise B — Rewrite the second clause or sentence using the passive to maintain continuity. Omit the by-phrase if it is not necessary.

1 Although the account had been posting abusive comments for weeks, moderators did not suspend it until yesterday.

2 A full year after the harassment began, a journalist discovered the account holder's real identity.

3 These trolls were not very careful. Investigators found evidence of their activity quite quickly.

4 The news usually includes positive stories about technology, but in recent months, stories of online abuse have dominated the coverage.

ACADEMIC WRITING
Writing about problems and solutions

ACADEMIC WRITING SKILL
Writing about problems

When presenting problems, writers use a range of strategies to show readers why a problem matters: facts (F), statistics (S), and examples (E) — especially ones that will resonate with the reader.

Read the statements below and label the strategy the writer uses: F, S or E.

1 Nearly two-thirds of teenagers say they have witnessed online harassment firsthand.

_____

2 After a wave of abusive reviews, a small family-run business lost almost half its regular customers.

_____

3 In a recent survey, 40% of students reported experiencing unwanted contact from strangers online.

_____

4 Some companies simply need a new logo to show that they have matured as a business.

_____

5 A user we'll call GreenFox92 lost access to her savings after someone found her personal details online

_____

6 An anonymous account has been sending threatening messages to a local teacher for more than five years.

_____

7 In several documented cases, exposing someone's private information online without consent has led to real-world harm.

_____

8 The most commonly reported platform for online harassment is social media.

_____

READING PRACTICE

PART 4

Read the following text for question 21-29.

PENGUINS

There are seventeen kinds of penguins in the world. They are all alike in some ways and all cannot fly. All have dark backs and white fronts and live in the Southern Hemisphere near the sea

They differ in several ways. They can be as small as 16 inches or as tall as 4 feet. They differ in the exact location they inhabit. Some live in the frigid climate of Antarctica. Others can live along the coast of forested land. Galapagos penguins live three thousand miles north of Antarctica in a tropical climate at the equator. All penguins live at or south of the equator.

Some penguins are known for yellow or orange feathers on their heads. Some have a single or double black band across their upper chest. Brush-tailed penguins have tails that are longer than any other. The emperor and the king are called the giant penguins. The little blue and the yellow-eyed are isolated types of penguins not related to any other. Sometimes penguins are named by what they look like. Sometimes they are named based on where they live

Penguins have torpedo-shaped bodies, long and slim. They can move quickly and gracefully through the sea. Their short wings and flippers move up and down swiftly. They steer with their tails and feet. Penguins have solid bones. This helps them dive. They can leap out of the water. They can travel twenty-five miles an hour for short distances. Some types of penguins may live in one area in summer and travel a good distance for the winter. The biggest penguins are the fastest swimmers and best divers. Emperors can dive as much as fifteen hundred feet below the surface of the ocean for prey, though food is much closer to them.

Penguins feed on fish, squid and krill. They have no teeth. Their tongues and roofs of their mouths are covered with stiff spines which keep slippery prey inside. A penguin comes up from below to strike a school of fish. In a few minutes a penguin can catch and eat a hundred small fish or krill.

Wherever penguins swim, the water is cold. Their coat of small, scale-like feathers protects them from the cold. Penguins can groom themselves by taking oil from a gland at the base of their tails. With their beaks they spread this oil all over their feathers. This is their way of waterproofing their bodies. A layer of stored fat under their skin also keeps them warm. It gives them extra energy when needed too. In warmer climates penguins may have bare skin on their faces to stay cooler.

Penguins could live all year in the sea but they must come ashore to mate and raise their babies. Most nests are made by the male. Both parents help raise the babies. In warm climates penguins must protect the eggs from the heat. Nests can be placed in crevices and caves along the shore. Penguins in colder climates build nests on top of soil or rocks out of pebbles. They are above ground to avoid being flooded by melting ice.

In spring more than a million king penguins raise their young on South Georgia Island in the southern part of the Atlantic Ocean. The male and female take turns holding a single egg on top of their feet. They keep it warm by holding it up to a special warm area of their belly skin called the brood patch. The other parent goes off to hunt for food.

In summary, all seventeen types of penguins in the world are alike in some ways. They are all flightless birds. They have dark backs and white fronts and live near the sea in the Southern Hemisphere.

For questions 21-24, choose the correct answer A, B, C, or D. Mark your answers on the answer sheet.

21. Which of the following are the two largest types of penguins?

A) King and emperor

B) Brush-tailed and emperor

C) Galapagos and king

D) None of the above

22. Which of the following reasons tells why penguins use the oil from the

gland at the base of their tail?

A) To protect their eyes from bright light

B) To waterproof their feathers

C) To keep their feet tough

D) To keep their beaks sharp

23. What is unusual about how the male and female emperor penguins on South Georgia Island take care of their egg?

A) They bury it in the sand.

B) The female sits on it for three weeks.

C) The male and female use a brood patch to keep the egg warm.

D) The parents leave the egg alone while they go off to hunt for food.

24. Penguins live …

A) anywhere.

B) Only in the forests of Galapagos.

C) at the equator.

D) in the frigid climate of Antarctica.

For questions 25-29, decide if the following statements agree with the information given in the text. Mark your answers on the answer sheet.

25. All penguins have black bands across their chests.

A) True B) False C) No Information

26. Penguins have sharp teeth.

A) True B) False C) No Information

27. Penguins eat small animals like fish and squid.

A) True B) False C) No Information

28. Penguins choose their partner for life.

A) True B) False C) No Information

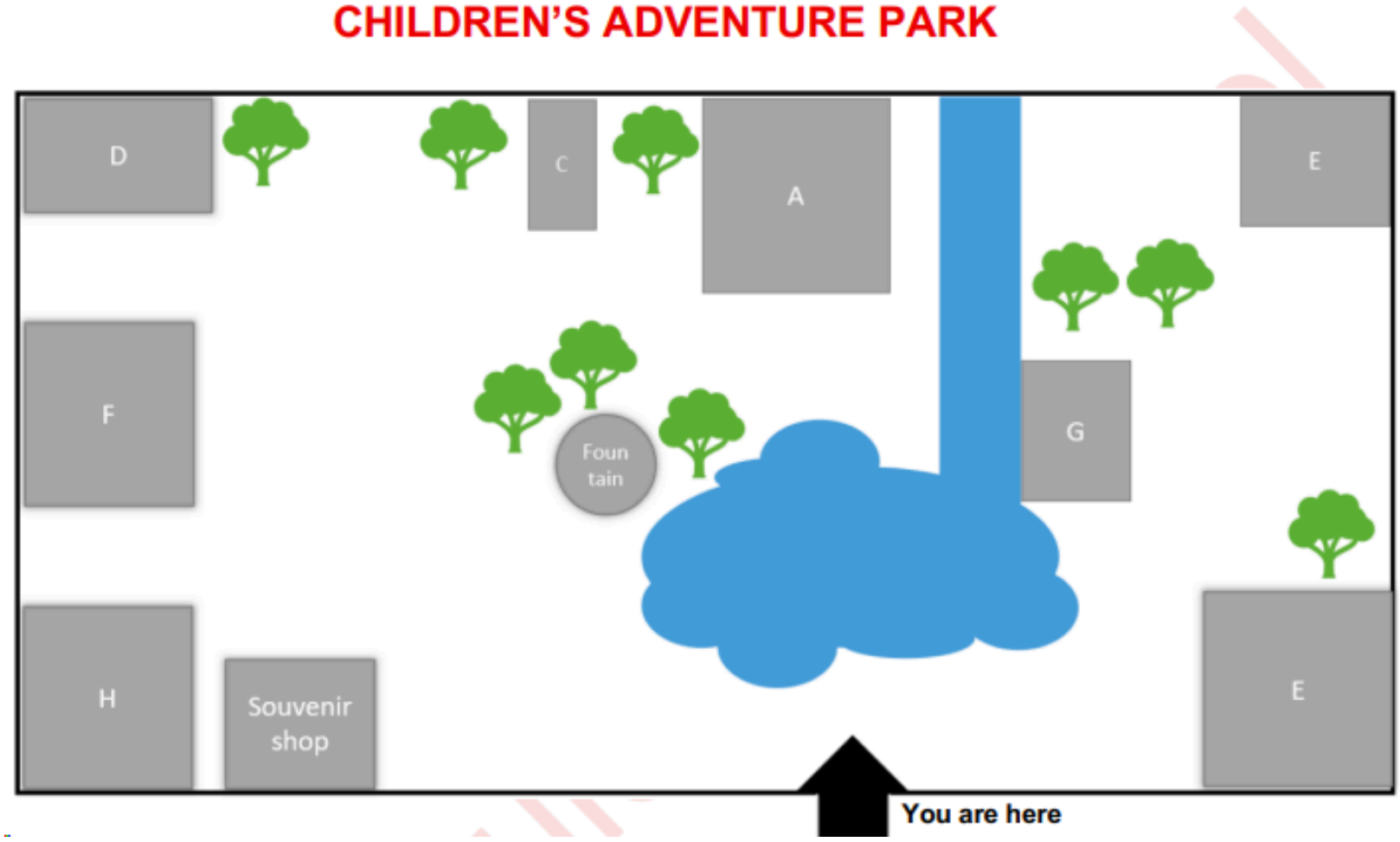
29. King penguins and emperor penguins dislike each other.

A) True B) False C) No Information

LISTENING PRACTICE

PART 4

You will hear someone giving a talk. Label the places (19-23) on the map (A-H). There are THREE extra options which you do not need to use.



19. Adventure course …

20. Restroom …

21. Swimming pool …

22. Tennis court …

23. Scary room